

Qualitative, Quantitative & Mixed Methods

Three method families — and how mixed designs combine them

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Quantitative methods collect and analyse numerical data to measure, compare and test relationships. Qualitative methods collect non-numerical data — words, images, observations — to explore meaning, process and context. Mixed methods deliberately combine both within one study to draw on the strengths of each. The mixed approach is not simply 'doing both'; it requires an explicit rationale for how and why the strands are integrated (Creswell and Plano Clark, 2018).

QUANTITATIVE

Numeric data; large samples; statistical analysis; tests hypotheses; prioritises breadth, comparison and generalisation. Instruments: structured questionnaires, existing datasets, scales. Answers 'how much', 'how many', 'is there a relationship'.

QUALITATIVE

Textual/visual data; smaller purposive samples; thematic or narrative analysis; builds understanding; prioritises depth, meaning and context. Instruments: interviews, focus groups, observation. Answers 'how' and 'why'.

Mixed methods needs a design, not just two datasets. State the sequence and priority: convergent (both at once, compare), explanatory sequential (quant then qual to explain), or exploratory sequential (qual then quant to test). And say at what point — design, collection, or interpretation — the strands integrate.

Feature	Qualitative	Quantitative	Mixed
Data	Words, images	Numbers	Both
Sample	Small, purposive	Large, representative	Both
Analysis	Thematic, narrative	Statistical	Integrated
Goal	Depth, meaning	Measure, test	Breadth + depth

JUSTIFY THE MIX

If mixed, explain what each strand adds that the other cannot. 'To triangulate' is a start; specify how the strands actually inform each other.

NAME THE DESIGN

Convergent, explanatory-sequential or exploratory-sequential — pick one and follow its logic in collection and analysis.

INTEGRATE, DON'T STAPLE

Weak mixed studies report two separate analyses. Strong ones bring the strands together at the interpretation stage.

Common pitfalls. (1) Calling a study mixed with no integration rationale. (2) A qualitative strand too thin to add value. (3) Mismatched samples that cannot be meaningfully combined. (4) Reporting quant and qual results in isolation with no synthesis.

REFERENCES

Creswell, J.W. and Plano Clark, V.L. (2018) *Designing and Conducting Mixed Methods Research*. 3rd edn. Thousand Oaks: SAGE. · Bryman, A. and Bell, E. (2015) *Business Research Methods*. 4th edn. Oxford: Oxford University Press.